

Executive Summary

A 2023 MENTOR study found that underserved youth in the U.S. face significant challenges in education and career readiness due to limited access to mentorship (Annie E. Casey Foundation, 2024). Give Merit's FATE Program addresses this gap by providing structured mentorship, academic support, and career readiness training to economically disadvantaged high school students (ages 14–18) in Detroit, Michigan.

Through a four-year, cohort-based model, students receive weekly academic mentoring, college and career counseling, financial literacy education, and project-based learning opportunities that foster leadership and entrepreneurship skills.

Give Merit seeks a \$250,000 investment over a four-year period to support 50 students, offering \$5,000 per participant, to help them graduate on time, pursue postsecondary education, and enter the workforce successfully.

Organization Information

Founded in 2011 by David Merritt and Kuhu Saha (Rebhan, 2017), Give Merit is a Detroit-based nonprofit providing mentorship, enrichment opportunities, and financial support to economically disadvantaged youth. The organization's flagship program, FATE, partners with the Jalen Rose Leadership Academy and corporate sponsors to deliver academic, leadership, and career development opportunities.

Problem Statement/Statement of Need

In Detroit, one in four high school students will not graduate on time (LeBlanc, 2024), and over half of children live in poverty (Geronimus et al., 2020). Roughly 28,000 youth are disconnected, neither in school nor employed (Koumpilova, 2024). These challenges are compounded by educational deficits: 96% of eighth graders are not proficient in math, and 93% are not proficient in reading (Staff Reporter, 2015).

These statistics reflect systemic inequities rooted in Detroit's long history of underfunded public schools, generational poverty, and limited access to higher education within families. Many students are raised in single-parent households by caregivers who did not attend college, reducing their access to academic guidance and career role models. Schools often lack the resources to provide individualized college counseling or real-world career exposure. In contrast, students in more affluent communities benefit from well-resourced school systems, strong mentorship pipelines, and intergenerational support. Detroit students are often left without the structured support systems, professional exposure, and consistent mentorship necessary to succeed.

Research shows that about 1 in 3 youth will reach age 19 without a mentor, and today's 18–21-year-olds are even less likely to have had a mentor than previous cohorts, partly due to

pandemic disruptions (MENTOR, 2023a), but when they are able to participate in sustained mentorship programs, they show significantly higher rates of high school graduation, college enrollment, and long-term career success (MENTOR, 2023b). Without access to these critical supports, Detroit youth remain vulnerable to cycles of poverty and limited economic mobility.

Program/Project Description and Partners

The FATE Program offers a comprehensive, four-year, cohort-based model that supports economically disadvantaged high school students in Detroit. Designed to fill critical mentorship, academic, and career development gaps, FATE engages students through weekly workshops, hands-on learning, and individualized support. The program focuses on building leadership, creativity, and career readiness through real-world experiences and long-term mentorship.

Each grade level in the FATE Program is aligned to a structured, skill-building theme:

- **9th Grade:** Marketing and branding development
- **10th Grade:** Entrepreneurship through product design
- **11th Grade:** Large-scale charity event planning
- **12th Grade:** Internships with local businesses and corporate partners

Students also participate in campus visits, internship placements, and career panels led by professionals in finance, healthcare, technology, marketing, and entrepreneurship. Throughout all four years, students receive mentorship, academic coaching, and guidance from dedicated FATE staff and trained volunteers including college students, educators, and industry professionals.

Graduating seniors receive tailored post-secondary support, including assistance with scholarship applications, FAFSA completion, and financial aid planning. Students do not receive full-tuition scholarships through FATE; rather, they are provided with financial guidance and awarded up to \$5,000 in support to cover costs such as tuition deposits, college application fees, housing deposits, and technology access.

Community Partners

Jalen Rose Leadership Academy (JRLA): Serves as the primary recruitment and partner school, ensuring that students have access to FATE programming and mentorship.

University of Michigan: Connects FATE students with college mentors, providing academic guidance and exposure to post-secondary environments.

Philanthropic Foundations: Ongoing funders include The Skillman Foundation, The McGregor Fund, and The Max M. & Marjorie S. Fisher Foundation, which sustain FATE's curriculum development and student support services.

Corporate Partners: Organizations such as Zingerman's, Plante Moran, Doner, Carhartt, Tapper's, and Creative Solutions Group contribute through mentorship, career workshops (e.g., mock interviews, industry panels), and internship opportunities.

Overall Goal and Objectives

To create a sustained pipeline of support for economically disadvantaged high school students in Detroit by embedding long-term mentorship, experiential learning, and postsecondary planning into all four years of their high school experience, ultimately positioning students for lifelong success in education and the workforce.

1. Increase High School Graduation Rates by Q4/2026

- **Activity 1:** Mentors will provide weekly academic support and guidance to students.
- **Activity 2:** Program staff will track student progress through GPA and attendance records each semester.
- **Performance Measure:** At least 90% of FATE students graduate on time.

2. Enhance Leadership and Professional Skills by Q4/2026

- **Activity 1:** 9th-grade students will complete a marketing and branding project by Q2 2025.
- **Activity 2:** 10th-grade students will design and pitch a product to local entrepreneurs by Q2 2026.
- **Activity 3:** 11th-grade students will organize and execute a charity event in Detroit by Q3 2026.
- **Performance Measure:** 100% of students complete three hands-on projects focused on leadership, teamwork, and business skills, as demonstrated through project submissions and mentor evaluations.

3. Provide Financial Support for Postsecondary Education by Q2/2026

- **Activity 1:** Program staff will assist eligible seniors in applying for scholarships and financial aid in Q4 2025.
- **Activity 2:** Financial literacy workshops will be held quarterly to prepare students for managing post secondary expenses.
- **Activity 3:** All eligible seniors will submit at least one financial aid application by Q1 2026.
- **Performance Measure:** 100% of eligible graduating FATE students receive financial assistance for college.

Evaluation Plan and Metrics of Success

The FATE Program will use a mixed-methods approach to evaluate both program implementation and student outcomes. Program staff and independent evaluators will track progress using attendance data, academic performance records, pre- and post-program surveys, project completion benchmarks, and college enrollment confirmations.

Quantitative measures will include:

- Semester GPA and course completion rates, gathered directly from JRLA student records
- High school graduation status of all senior participants
- FAFSA and scholarship submission confirmations
- Number of students completing projects (branding, product design, event planning, internships)
- Postsecondary enrollment within 6 months of graduation, verified through National Student Clearinghouse or institutional reports

Qualitative measures will include:

- Pre- and post-program self-assessments of students' leadership, confidence, and future planning skills
- Feedback from mentors and corporate partners on student engagement and preparedness
- Exit interviews conducted with 12th-grade students to assess perceived impact and suggestions for improvement

Evaluation activities will be led by the FATE Program Manager and Education Coordinator, with data compiled quarterly. Insights will be reviewed by Give Merit leadership bi-annually to inform program improvements and support ongoing funding proposals.

Financial Sustainability Plan

- **Multi-Year Grants and Philanthropic Support:** Ongoing partnerships with Skillman, McGregor Fund, and Fisher Foundation.
- **Corporate and Community Sponsorships:** Expanding industry partnerships for mentorship, internships, and financial contributions.
- **Earned Revenue Model:** 20% of Merit apparel sales fund FATE.
- **Individual Giving & Fundraising Events:** Annual campaigns, benefit events, and major donor engagement.
- **Alumni and Volunteer Engagement:** FATE alumni return as mentors and program advocates, contributing financially and professionally.

References

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